



BEFORE

The unavoidable disorganization and confusion in forming both the Northern and Southern armies masked the North's overwhelming material superiority.

SOUTHERN OPPORTUNITY

The North had vastly **greater resources than the South** (see [A well-resourced enemy](#)). But its impressive industrial and economic capacity had to be organized and mobilized before it became militarily useful—and this gave the Confederacy a timely **opportunity to win independence**.

AN IDENTICAL MILITARY MODEL

Both sections used the prewar U.S. Army as a common administrative and tactical model for creating **new field armies**. Veterans such as Josiah Gorgas utilized their expertise to help the Confederacy **mobilize its limited resources**.

CENTRAL AUTHORITY

Given the South's avowed **attachment to states' rights**, it was difficult for President [Jefferson Davis](#) to impose the centralized organization **essential to military efficiency**.

By the time of the Civil War, the American Revolution was a distant memory, and few citizens had served in the more recent War with Mexico (1846–47), in which General Winfield Scott had conquered Mexico City with an army of only 11,000 men. Attitudes to war tended to romanticize it, drawing on a variety of cultural influences: tributes to the Founding Fathers and the American Revolution; images of overseas wars in exotic settings, such as French Algeria or the Halls of Montezuma in Mexico; and the long-standing militia tradition whereby common people banded together to defeat their enemies, returning home after a short but sharp war.

25 The percentage of U.S. Army officers who resigned to take up arms against their country.

A nation's differences

Sectionalism added potently to this collection of ideas. Southerners saw themselves as a martial people more familiar with horses and weapons than shopkeeping Yankees. Northerners believed they were a free people defending the Constitution. They were fighting against a society ruled by abusive enslavers who had been corrupted by the illegitimate power they held over fellow human beings.